Episode 1

The House of Mourning

ផ្ទះបុណ្យ

Game Design and Narrative Specification

Setting	Family stilt house, rural Battambang Province
In-story time	8:12 PM (prologue) · 11:30 PM – about 4:30 AM
Playtime	3 – 4 hours
Seal	#1 · The Bronze Token
Version	2.0 · October 2026 · Draft for review

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01 Episode Overview

A broken phone call pulls Sora home to Battambang for her uncle's funeral. Left alone to keep the night vigil over his coffin, she discovers that Uncle Sok did not die of illness: he tried to break an ancestral pact with a land spirit, and the spirit is now inside the house.

LOCATION	ERA	PLAYTIME
Battambang Province	**1932**	**3 – 4 hours**
Family estate and teak stilt house	French Protectorate of Cambodia	Prologue + 3 acts

CORE MECHANIC	ENTITY	SEAL
Resource management	**Neak Ta manifestation**	**#1 Bronze Token**
Kerosene, incense, matches	Shadow with a brass mask	Burned in a counter-ritual

1.1 Episode goal

Survive the funeral vigil until dawn, uncover why Uncle Sok died, and find and burn the **Bronze Token**, the first of the pact's five seals, before 3:00 AM.

1.2 Role in the series

Introduces	Movement and interaction, the satchel and sketchbook, the kerosene lamp, timed upkeep (incense), hiding, the "moves when unwatched" scare, and the first counter-ritual.
Reveals	The 1910 pact between Sora's great-grandfather and a Neak Ta, and Uncle Sok's failed attempt to break it.
Leads to	A line of blood on Sora's map points to the village pagoda, the setting of Episode 2.

1.3 Visual identity

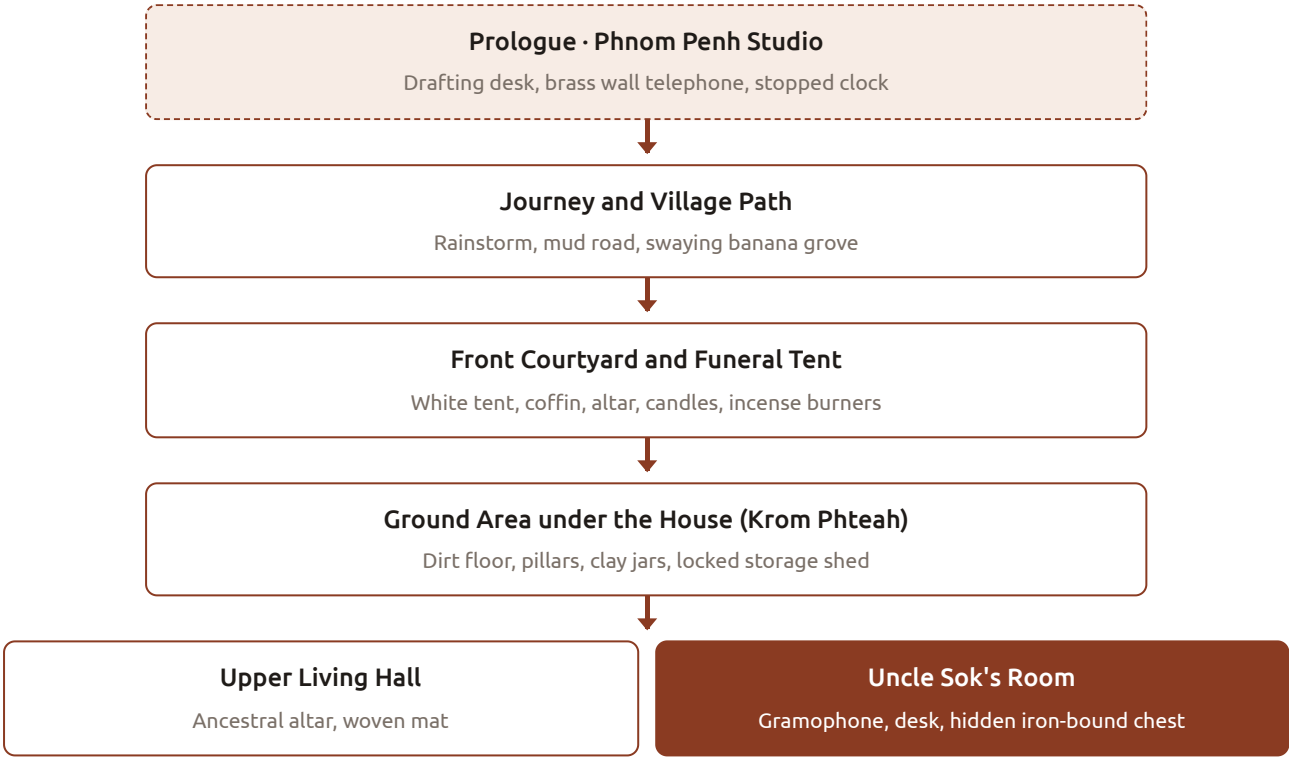
A 1930s photograph come to life: film grain, high-contrast chiaroscuro lighting, sepia-tinted shadows, polished teak, reflective wet mud and the restless shadows of oil flames.

02 Characters

Character	Role	Description	Gameplay function
Sora ស៊ូរ៉ា 24	Protagonist	An independent, educated illustrator who left her village years ago for Phnom Penh. She carries a leather drafting satchel with her sketchbook, fountain pens, brass matches and a hurricane lamp.	Player character. Seen only as hands in first person.
Yay Mey យាយមី 78	Grandmother, family matriarch	Traditional, strict and deeply superstitious. Dressed in white mourning clothes: a chong kben (សំពត់ចងក្បិន) and a silk sash (ខ្សែ). Exhausted after two days of mourning.	Sets the three vigil duties; quest giver and voice of tradition.
Uncle Sok ពូសុខ deceased	Sora's estranged uncle	An eccentric collector of ancient manuscripts and relics who lived alone in the family's ancestral stilt house. Died in 1931 attempting a forbidden ritual.	His journal pages drive the story; his corpse and portrait are scare devices.
The Entity Neak Ta manifestation	Antagonist	A towering figure wrapped in shadow, wearing a distorted ancient brass mask. It appears as a dark silhouette that shifts position in or near the coffin when no one is watching.	Mostly scripted encounters; hunts by sound upstairs and under the house.

03 Locations and Layout

3.1 Progression map



3.2 Area details

Area	Description and key props	Lighting	Gameplay use
Phnom Penh Studio Prologue	A cosy third-floor apartment in 1930s Phnom Penh. Wooden drafting table, ink bottles, typography prints, a green glass desk lamp, a brass hand-crank wall telephone, and a mechanical wall clock that stops at 8:12 PM.	Warm desk lamp, a candle, lightning through the window	Tutorial: movement, interaction, collecting the starting kit
Village Path	The final stretch on foot after the carriage driver refuses to continue. Muddy road, banana groves bending in the storm.	Sora's lamp only; lightning flashes	Lamp tutorial; mood setting

Area	Description and key props	Lighting	Gameplay use
Courtyard and Funeral Tent ពាងបុណ្យ	An open bamboo-framed tent draped in coarse, wet white cotton that flaps in the wind. Raised wooden stage with the decorated teak coffin; framed black-and-white portrait of Uncle Sok on a small altar with brass candle holders; four tall brass incense burners at the coffin's corners; woven bamboo benches, clay water jars; protective white cotton thread tied along the frame.	Hanging glass oil lamps and thick yellow wax candles against pitch-black night	Vigil hub: incense loop, thread checks, final ritual
Upper Teak House ផ្ទះពាងដឿង	Dark teak construction with 1 cm gaps between floorboards (light and shadows show through) and a high-gabled roof of terracotta tiles. **Living hall:** large woven bamboo mat (កន្ទេល), ancestral altar with small bronze statues and betel trays. **Uncle Sok's room:** cluttered desk with fountain pens, stacks of dried palm-leaf manuscripts (ស្លឹករឹត), a brass-horn gramophone, and an iron-bound wooden chest hidden behind loose wall planks.	Very dark; moonlight through shutter gaps	Exploration, gramophone puzzle, hiding, chest
Under the House ក្រោមផ្ទះ	Open-air dirt floor beneath the raised living space, ringed by thick wooden pillars. Stacked firewood, ox-cart wheels, clay water jars and a locked storage shed at the back.	Pitch black except the lamp	Stealth search for key fragments

04 Story and Gameplay by Act

Two kinds of time appear below: **playtime** (how far into the episode the player is) and **story time** (the clock in the game world).

Prologue · The Call in Phnom Penh

Playtime 0:00 – 0:25 · Story 8:00 – 8:15 PM

NARRATIVE

Sora is working late on an illustration commission while a tropical storm rages outside. A sudden, inexplicable dread grips her. Her hands tremble and ink spills across her sketchbook. A candle on the shelf goes out, and the wall clock stops dead at **8:12 PM**.

The brass wall telephone rings sharply. Through heavy static, her grandmother's voice is panicking:

> *"Sora… you must come home right now… Uncle Sok… he broke it… it's inside the house—"*
>
> Yay Mey, over the telephone

A screech cuts through the line, then shattering glass and heavy thuds. Sora drops the earpiece, which hangs from its cord, hissing dead static.

GAMEPLAY

Element	Description
Controls tutorial	Look, walk, pick up and inspect objects, open drawers, answer the telephone.
Starting kit	Collect the leather satchel, sketchbook, brass matchbox and kerosene hurricane lamp before leaving.
First sketchbook entry	The ink-spilled page becomes the sketchbook's first entry and teaches the player how to open it.

Act I · Arrival and the Vigil

Playtime 0:25 – 1:15 · Story 11:30 PM – 1:00 AM

NARRATIVE

After an overnight train and a horse-drawn carriage through the storm, Sora reaches her family's village at **11:30 PM**. The driver refuses to take the flooded road, so she walks the last stretch through the banana groves by the light of her hurricane lamp.

In the courtyard stands the white funeral tent in front of the family stilt house. Yay Mey greets her in tears. Exhausted after two days of mourning, she asks Sora to keep the late-night watch over Uncle Sok's body and gives her three sacred duties:

1. **Keep the lamp burning:** never let the hurricane lamp run out of kerosene.
2. **Keep the incense alight:** the four incense sticks at the corners of the coffin must never burn out.

3. **Keep the thread whole:** the protective white cotton thread around the tent must stay unbroken.

GAMEPLAY

Element	Description
Kerosene management	The lamp's oil gauge drains steadily. The player searches the house and grounds for spare oil bottles.
Incense loop	Every 10–12 minutes the incense burns down. Fresh sticks come from the altar inside the house. If they burn out, the light dims and whispers grow louder.
Diegetic sketchbook	Clues, maps and symbols are drawn into the sketchbook automatically as Sora investigates.
Thread checks	The player can walk the tent's perimeter to inspect the thread, which builds tension for the moment it snaps in Act III.

Act II · The Unbroken Taboo

Playtime 1:15 – 2:30 · Story 1:00 – 2:00 AM

NARRATIVE

At **1:00 AM**, a cold gust blows out the oil lamps under the tent. Heavy, wet footsteps echo across the floorboards of the house above.

Upstairs, Uncle Sok's door stands ajar. Behind a loose wall plank, Sora finds pages from his 1931 journal. They reveal that he did not die of illness. He attempted a forbidden ritual to break a pact that Sora's great-grandfather made with a land guardian spirit, a Neak Ta, in 1910. Sok failed to bind the spirit, and it struck him down.

GAMEPLAY

Element	Description
Gramophone puzzle	The brass-horn gramophone starts playing a funeral chant backwards on its own. Adjusting its speed dial reveals a spoken clue to where the desk-drawer key is hidden (see section 6.1).
Hiding	Dragging footsteps approach in the hallway. Sora must put out her lamp and hide behind a wooden wardrobe until the shadow passes the doorway.
The altered portrait	Back downstairs, all four incense sticks have turned to white ash, whatever the player did. In the portrait on the altar, Uncle Sok's eyes are now open and staring at Sora.

Act III · The First Seal

Playtime 2:30 – 3:30 · Story 2:00 – 3:00 AM

NARRATIVE

A violent **snap** echoes across the yard: the main protective thread has broken in two. The oil lamps go out one by one and the darkness creeps inward. Inside the coffin, Uncle Sok's body shifts position whenever Sora turns her back.

Using the translated journal pages, Sora realises she must find the **Bronze Token of the Neak Ta**, locked away in the house, and perform a counter-ritual before **3:00 AM**.

GAMEPLAY

Element	Description
Under-house search	In the pitch-black area under the house, Sora tracks a roaming shadow by 3D sound while collecting three brass key fragments hidden inside clay water jars.
Unlocking the chest	Upstairs, the assembled key opens the iron-bound chest. Inside: the Bronze Token (Seal #1) and a map with four other locations marked across Cambodia.
Counter-ritual and climax	Sora places the token in the main incense burner and lights it with sanctified matches while reciting the counter-mantra. The entity appears directly behind her, its huge shadow thrown across the white tent cloth. She must finish the lighting sequence **without turning around**.

Resolution and Cliffhanger

Story about 3:00 – 4:30 AM

As the token burns, a blast of wind tears through the white tent. The entity lets out an echoing screech that fades into the night. Quiet returns, and in the last hours before dawn the first grey light rises over the banana groves.

The curse on the house is broken for now, and Uncle Sok's body settles peacefully. But when Sora opens her sketchbook, a fresh line of dark blood bleeds across the map, pointing straight to the village pagoda and setting up **Episode 2: The Whispering Pagoda**.

05 Mechanics Reference

Values marked *target* are starting points to tune during playtesting.

Mechanic	Rules	Feedback to the player
Kerosene lamp	Burns oil continuously while lit. A full tank lasts about 12 minutes (*target*). Spare oil bottles refill it. The lamp can be turned off to save oil or to hide.	Glass gauge on the lamp; the flame shrinks and sputters when low.
Matches	Limited supply in the brass matchbox. Needed to relight the lamp, candles and incense, and for the final ritual (sanctified matches).	Count visible when the matchbox is opened.
Incense loop	The four corner sticks burn down every 10–12 minutes. Replacing all four resets the timer. Letting them burn out darkens the tent and raises whispering and entity activity until they are replaced.	Stick length; smoke thinning; whispers.
Protective thread	Story-driven in this episode: it breaks at a scripted moment in Act III. Inspecting it beforehand is optional but builds tension.	Visual state of the thread; the snap sound.
Hiding	Standing in a hiding spot (behind a wardrobe or in deep shadow) with the lamp off makes Sora undetectable unless the entity bumps into her.	Muffled sound, heartbeat, darker view.
Watched / unwatched	The corpse (and later the entity) moves only when it is outside the player's view.	Changed position when the player looks back.
"Do not turn around"	During the final ritual, turning the camera past a set angle fails the sequence and restarts it from its checkpoint.	Shadow on the tent cloth; breathing behind the player.
Being caught	A short scare, fade to black, and a restart at the last checkpoint. There is no health bar.	Screen distortion, sound, torn sketchbook page.

06 Puzzle Walkthroughs

6.1 The gramophone

Step	Action	Result
1	Enter Uncle Sok's room; the gramophone starts playing a reversed chant by itself.	Unsettling sound; points the player to the machine.
2	Inspect the gramophone and find the governor speed dial.	Dial becomes interactive.
3	Turn the dial until the warped audio becomes clear speech.	A spoken clue reveals where the desk-drawer key is hidden.
4	Retrieve the key and open the desk drawer.	Further journal pages and a translation aid.

6.2 The brass key and the chest

Step	Action	Result
1	Read the journal: the chest key was broken into three pieces and hidden under the house.	Objective sketched in the sketchbook.
2	Search the clay water jars under the house while avoiding the roaming shadow.	Three brass key fragments, one per jar.
3	Combine the fragments in the satchel.	Complete key.
4	Remove the loose wall planks in Uncle Sok's room and unlock the iron-bound chest.	Bronze Token (Seal #1) and the map of four locations.

6.3 The counter-ritual

Step	Action	Result
1	Carry the token to the coffin altar before 3:00 AM.	Ritual begins; checkpoint saved.
2	Place the token in the main incense burner.	The entity appears behind Sora.
3	Strike sanctified matches and light the burner while the mantra is recited, without turning around.	The token burns; the seal breaks.

07 Entities

Entity	Where	Behaviour	How to survive
Neak Ta manifestation	Tent, coffin, upper house	Mostly scripted: footsteps above, a silhouette near the coffin, and the final appearance behind Sora during the ritual.	Follow the ritual; never turn around.
Hallway shadow	Upper house	Walks the hallway with heavy, dragging footsteps. Investigates light and noise.	Put out the lamp and hide behind a wardrobe.
Roaming shadow	Under the house	Patrols between the pillars and hunts mainly by sound.	Move slowly, track it by 3D audio, keep pillars between you.
Uncle Sok's corpse	Coffin	Shifts position only when unwatched. Not directly dangerous; a pure dread device.	None needed.

08 Items and Collectibles

Item	Type	Found / use
Leather satchel	Equipment	Studio. Holds the inventory; opened to access everything else.
Sketchbook	Equipment	Studio. Maps, clues, journal translations and objectives.
Kerosene hurricane lamp	Equipment	Studio. Main light source.
Brass matchbox	Consumable	Studio. Lighting the lamp, candles and incense.
Spare oil bottles	Consumable	House and grounds. Refill the lamp.
Incense sticks	Consumable	House altar. Replace the corner sticks.
Desk-drawer key	Key item	Found via the gramophone clue.
Brass key fragments ×3	Key item	Clay jars under the house; combine into the chest key.
Sanctified matches	Key item	Needed for the counter-ritual. *Source to be decided* (for example, Yay Mey or the altar).
Bronze Token	Seal #1	Iron-bound chest. Burned in the counter-ritual.
Map of four locations	Story item	Iron-bound chest. Becomes the series map.
Uncle Sok's journal pages (1931)	Lore	Behind the wall plank and in the desk. Reveal the pact.

DESIGN NOTE

Place several **hidden optional lore notes** in this episode (for example letters, photographs and village records). Episode 5's true ending depends on how many the player collects across the series.

09 Audio and Visual Specification

Colour palette	Sepia, dark mahogany, warm amber flame orange, cold off-white linen, wet mud grey.
Post-processing	1930s film grain, chromatic aberration, lens vignetting, dynamic shadows.
Light sources	Sora's kerosene hurricane lamp, hanging glass oil lamps, wax candles, moonlight, lightning.
Ambience	Heavy rain, rolling thunder, night cicadas, bullfrogs, creaking teak.
Horror sound cues	Backward gramophone chant, mechanical clock chimes, the snapping thread, heavy dragging footsteps, telephone static, whispers.
Music	Sparse and ominous, drawing on Pinpeat (ពិណពាទ្យ) tones; mostly silence and ambience.
Interface	100% diegetic, with no on-screen HUD. The oil gauge is on the lamp; inventory and map are in Sora's satchel and sketchbook.

10 Glossary

Term (v1)	Khmer	Meaning	Note
Boon Sop	បុណ្យសព	Funeral ceremony	Series title
Neak Ta	អ្នកតា	Guardian spirit of a place or land	
Rong Sop	ឧោងបុណ្យ	Funeral tent / pavilion	Confirm preferred term
Phteah Rong Doeung	ផ្ទះឧោងដើង	Traditional gabled Khmer house	
Krom Phteah	ក្រោមផ្ទះ	The space under a stilt house	
Kanteal	កន្ទេល	Woven mat	
Sleok Rith	ស្លឹករឹត	Palm-leaf manuscript	
Chong Kben / Sbai	សំពត់ចងក្បិន / សៃ្ប	Wrapped trousers / shoulder sash	
Mneang Sop	មឈូស	Coffin	v1 term unclear; "mchhous" suggested
Pheon	ពាង	Large clay water jar	v1 term unclear; "peang" suggested
Chhenglang	ចង្កៀង	Oil lamp	v1 term unclear; "changkieng" suggested
Sai Sin	—	Protective white cotton thread	"Sai sin" is the Thai/Lao term; confirm the Khmer term

All Khmer spellings, including character names, should be confirmed by a native speaker and cultural advisor before they appear in the game.

11 Revision Notes and Open Issues

Changes from v1.0

- Reorganised into a standard structure with a mechanics reference, puzzle walkthroughs, entity and item tables and a glossary.
- Added story-clock times to every act alongside playtime.
- Khmer text now renders correctly (it appeared as empty boxes in v1.0).
- "Sunlight… as 4:00 AM approaches" changed to "first grey light". Sunrise in Cambodia is around 5:30–6:00 AM.
- Defined a fail state (checkpoint restart, no health bar) and target values for oil and incense.

Open issues

DECIDE BEFORE BUILDING EPISODE 1

- **The pact's history:** Episode 2 shows an offering at a forest altar while Episode 4 describes a contract signed at a rubber estate. The journal pages here must match whichever version is chosen.
- **Date of the pact:** large rubber estates in Kampong Cham mostly date from the 1920s, so 1910 may need adjusting.
- **Sora's parents and Yay Mey's place in the bloodline** are never explained, though the curse runs for "four generations".
- **The map's "four other locations":** consider making them faint marks revealed one at a time by the blood trail, to preserve the mystery.
- **Source of the sanctified matches** for the final ritual.
- **The locked storage shed:** v1.0 says the token is "locked inside the under-house storage shed" but then retrieves it from the chest upstairs. Here the token is in the chest. Give the shed a purpose (for example, oil bottles or a lore note) or remove it.
- **Hidden lore notes and cross-episode tracking** for the Episode 5 endings.